



“GUN VIOLENCE SHOULD BE declared an epidemic in this country. It results in a dozen deaths every day.”

BINALAKSHMI NEPRAM,
SOCIAL WORKER, 34

When Binalakshmi Nepram was a teenager, she thought guns and violence were part of growing up. In the strife-torn North-east, levels of violence have now crossed those of Jammu and Kashmir. Manipur, her home state on the Myanmar border, adjoins the infamous drug hotspot, the Golden Triangle. Here guns and drugs enjoy an incestuous relationship with the ongoing insurgency. The result: over 700 people were shot dead and 300 women were widowed through gun-related violence in Manipur last year.

Two incidents brought the conflict closer home. In 1997, her 12-year-old niece was killed when she stepped on an improvised explosive device meant for a politician. Six years later, insurgents threatened to kill her parents after they refused to pay Rs 8 lakh as protection money. A two-year stint in London with the NGO Safer World made Nepram aware that the story of conflict zones was universal. She came back to discover that women, sandwiched between the army and militants, were unwitting targets. In 2004, she founded the Manipur Women Gun Survivors' Network (MWGSN). The MWGSN now supports 50 women by providing them bank accounts and loans to help them set



BANDEEP SINGH

up small businesses. Four years ago, to raise the debate on rising defence expenditure, Nepram began the Control Arms Foundation of India. “How will importing 126 fighter aircraft for Rs 50,000 crore protect me from gun-toting terrorists?” she wonders. These are hard questions but she is determined to find the answers. **by Sandeep Unnithan**

The Way Ahead

Creating chapters of women gun survivor networks in other areas affected by arm violence like Assam, Jammu and Kashmir, Bihar and Nagaland.

V. SVARAM

“ALL CHILDREN MUST BE ABLE TO CHOOSE careers based on their aspirations rather than financial backgrounds.”

GLORIA BENNY,
SOCIAL WORKER, 23

MAD. That is what they call themselves. But the catchy acronym for Make A Difference is doing exactly what it sought to by imparting quality education to orphans and other less privileged children. Within three years, Gloria Benny who started MAD with five friends in Kochi has enlisted more than 400 volunteers there as well as

in Pune, Hyderabad and Chennai to reach out to more than 1,200 children. By June, MAD will have core teams in Thiruvananthapuram, Mumbai, Goa, Mangalore and Delhi, covering 35 orphanages and another 1,500 children to make it one of India's fastest growing youth networks. MAD has already bagged the coveted Ashoka/Staples Youth Social Entrepreneur Award for 2008. The organisation enables children to improve their skills in English and computers. The volunteers spend two hours a week, each with a maximum of eight children, and must teach them for six months without a break. Benny, a senior AdWords Representative with Google in Hyderabad, is also planning to tie up with retail chains and IT companies to ensure jobs for these children in the future. And to accomplish these plans, madness is what is required. **by Amarnath K. Menon**



Moment of Truth

The discovery that the YMCA Poor Boys' Home in Kochi produced only one graduate in five years prompted the MAD founders to start their network.